

A Guide for Inquirers into the Orthodox Church

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Introduction

For most people who are inquiring into the Church, the best way to begin is simply to come to the services and also, talk to us. The more services you attend, the better. It may feel a bit like a baptism by fire because Orthodox services can be confusing at first, but over time, you will begin to understand them. Eventually, you will feel at home.

Just a little bit about St Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney TX

We have two priests in our parish. Archpriest Seraphim Holland is the Rector, and the author of this letter. Priest Nicholas Park is the assistant pastor. He is bilingual and can also serve and teach those who understand the Russian language better.

St Nicholas is at 708 S Chestnut, McKinney, TX 75069. If you are interested in coming to our services or teaching, we are happy to welcome you. It doesn't matter what you believe or don't believe or know or don't know; we are confident that you will feel welcome and edified.

Fr Seraphim catechizes most of the English speakers, and Fr Nicholas catechizes those that prefer Russian or cannot speak English fluently, but both of us serve as resources for anyone in the parish.

You can learn all kinds of things about our church, and literally thousands of articles about the Orthodox faith by looking at our website, www.orthodox.net, and our [YouTube](#) page. We also have an [Instagram](#) and [Facebook](#) page.

Come and see!

The advice that Philip gave to Nathaniel when he was wondering who Christ was: "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" was: "Come and see!" If this encounter had occurred in our modern era, Philip would absolutely *not* have said to Nathaniel, "Look it up on the web," or "watch this podcast," or "read this book."

The modern era, with its social media, may have gotten you to the church, but you cannot understand the church without experiencing it from within. This experience is one not only of coming to the services; it is also trying to enter into the prayer of Orthodoxy, which is completely different in essence than other Western prayers, and as you are experiencing these things, reading the scriptures and trying to understand them in the context of the church that wrote them, and also, when you are ready, entering into our day-to-day ascetical practices such as fasting and establishing a prayer rule. Please do not expect everything to be familiar to you. It won't be. Even if you have seen it "all" on YouTube, the full experience will be unfamiliar to you.

How to Act When You Come

When you first come, all you need to do is walk through the door—just don't bring a tuba! By that I mean, come simply and reverently. You may see people venerating icons, making the sign of the cross, or being anointed with oil. These are not requirements, but you are welcome to participate. The only thing you cannot participate in is partaking of the Eucharist, or "communion". You can tell that we are giving communion for the priest is standing near the front of the church holding the chalice, and people are coming up to the chalice and he is giving them communion with the spoon. This sacrament is only for Orthodox, and if you have questions about why, please ask us with a hat or scarf.

Dress modestly, as you would for an office. Women in our parish generally wear dresses or skirts and cover their heads with a hat or scarf, but we make no requirements of visitors. We provide head coverings for those who wish to use them, but there is no uniform.

Come as you are, respectfully. We don't really care about how you are dressed; if you want to be with us, please come. If you decide to come to our church and you're wearing shorts, come. If you have a choice and time, it's probably better to wear something different, but nobody is going to talk to you about what you're wearing or not wearing.

Is there anything that you could do that's really wrong in our services? Basically, no, unless you bring a tuba. Just be yourself, imitate what we do if you wish, and be ready to ask any question, and you will get an answer from us.

The Nature of Orthodox Worship

The significant difference between Orthodox Christian services and those of other Christian confessions is that you will know exactly what we believe from the prayers themselves. In many places outside Orthodoxy, songs are often about praise but are not very theological. Even among Roman Catholics today, there is very little theology in their services, and most people only attend Mass on Sundays. In the Orthodox Church, however, we have services in the evening to prepare for the Divine Liturgy the next morning. Especially on Saturday night, the service is rich, filled with theology, and centered on the Resurrection. When I first encountered Orthodox worship, I was amazed by its beauty. Though it takes time to grow familiar with it, this effort will reward you greatly.

That is not all there is.

Attending an Orthodox worship service is a bit like going to visit the Louve museum in Paris. There is no way you can see it all in one day. One service does not tell you everything we believe or emphasize.

For instance, if you attend the Divine Liturgy, you will see reverence and holiness, lots of singing, lots of censing, and clearly an emphasis on the partaking of the Eucharist. If it is during the week, there may not be a sermon because of time considerations. We have a Divine Liturgy at 6 AM on Thursday for people who need to go to work directly after the service. It would be unfair to them to have a sermon in the middle of the liturgy as we do on Sunday, especially one of mine, which can run up to 30 minutes! Out of consideration for them, we do not have a sermon. If someone comes to that liturgy, they may say: "Oh no, these people don't talk about the Bible; they don't emphasize the Bible; they don't preach about the Bible - I don't like that". The actual truth is that we talk about the Bible VERY OFTEN. We teach it frequently, and we give sermons about it frequently, including on Saturday evenings and Sunday

mornings, as well as sometimes on weekday mornings. I use it as the basis of my catechesis of catechumens, etc. Anybody who knows me knows that I will encourage people to read the Gospels almost every time I speak to them.

If a person attends a weekday service, they may be confused because there's a lot of chanting of Psalms, which may be unfamiliar to them, and we don't read the Gospel in most of our evening services or preach about it.

Perhaps they would come to a service which is a supplication service to the Mother of God, and because of their background, they would think that's very strange, and that there is an overemphasis on Mary and an underemphasis on Jesus Christ. That's not remotely true when you look at the full corpus of our services, and also when you understand the full ramifications of the "yes" of the Virgin Mary when she was told that with her consent she would bear the God man Jesus Christ.

The only way to really understand our worship is to attend everything eventually. And by attending, I mean that you would pray while you're there, try to pay attention, and ideally, receive service texts and read the services. They are a treasure trove of theology. Another aspect of learning about Orthodoxy is that as we attend the services, we are also reading the scriptures. It is imperative that we read the Gospels regularly, if not daily. If you read three chapters of the Gospels every day, you will complete the Gospels every month. And if you attend the services, you will see the entire Gospel taught, especially in our vigil service (on Saturday evening every week), and some other evening services, such as Vespers.

Oh, and by the way, I also emphasize reading the Psalter. I think everybody should strive to read it daily. Of course there are Psalms in the middle of your Bible, but an Orthodox Psalter is far superior. All of our prayer is very much like the Psalter, which is a beautiful and mysterious book. You must read it hundreds of times to begin to really understand it. Other than the Gospels and epistles of the New Testament, it is more than any other book about Jesus Christ and about developing inner prayer.

Why People Come to Orthodoxy

People are drawn to Orthodoxy for many different reasons. Some are interested in the mystical or Eastern aspects of the faith. Others come because they feel an emptiness in how their previous confession worshiped or taught. Some come because their spouse is Orthodox. Many come after extensive study and listening to talks online, convinced that Orthodoxy is the true Church. This intellectual path is a good beginning, but Orthodoxy is not embraced by reason alone. Our reason should lead to a conversion of the heart, which happens when we are exposed to Orthodox prayer and practice. Through this exposure, we recognize what is lacking in our lives, and repentance, catharsis, and change follow.

Similarities and Differences with Other Christians

Someone comparing the Orthodox Church with other Christian confessions will notice similarities and differences. Some differences can be difficult to accept at first, while others feel like a breath of fresh air after being in a smoky room. Everyone's journey is different.

Practical Guidance for Inquirers

The best step is to attend services and speak with us. It is also helpful to begin using an Orthodox prayer book with guidance, to learn how we interpret Scripture, and to become familiar with practices that benefit the soul. One of these practices is fasting on certain days, something uncommon in the Western world. We also venerate the saints and especially the Mother of God, who bore our Lord Jesus Christ in her pure virginal womb. We have reasons for all these practices, and it is always good to ask questions. Yet if someone only asks questions without entering into Orthodox worship and practice, they often become confused and dissatisfied.

The Most Important Question

I always ask people the most important question in the universe: "What is the purpose of your life?" And the second: "How do you fulfill that purpose?" Everything the Church does, teaches, and values is connected to these questions.

Icons and Theology

Our walls are covered with icons. This can be surprising to some, but for us, it is a proclamation of the Incarnation. Icons also proclaim that the prayers of the righteous are powerful, and the saints remain alive in Christ after physical death. Therefore, we ask for their intercessions and honor them as part of the living Church.

The Shape of Orthodox Services

Our services use the Psalms extensively. Many are read verbatim, others are woven into hymns and imagery. Everything is sung or chanted without musical instruments. We use incense often, and there is a great deal of movement since we do not have pews. Children are part of the services, sometimes noisy as children can be, but fully embraced by the community. The absence of pews gives freedom of movement and, in some ways, helps maintain peace.

The Central Theme: The Resurrection

Every Saturday evening service prepares us for the Sunday Liturgy, and its central theme is always the Resurrection. We never tire of proclaiming the Resurrection, for it touches every part of our lives at all times and in all places.

Learning the Rhythm of Services

At first, things may feel fast and overwhelming. But the services have a definite rhythm and repeated elements that make them familiar over time. Just as with reading Scripture, every return to the services reveals something new and deeper.

Resources and links

The most important resource that we can offer you is ourselves. Please plan to attend the catechesis on Sunday morning whenever possible, and listen to the sessions you missed on our [YouTube channel](#). It is always after our Divine liturgy. We serve liturgy at about 9 AM, and then we eat at noon, and catechesis is at 1 PM.

Our website is www.orthodox.net. It has the latest articles and YouTube videos available, and also a calendar of upcoming services and events, right on the front page.

We publish the catechesis on YouTube. Go to www.youtube.com/orthodoxnet. The most recent offerings will surely have catechesis sessions as well as recent homilies and talks.

Our playlist, "Catechism," contains a wealth of catechetical material. You can see it here: <https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLEh2brXYUf7nTCP-MRxaKWDHXnYVB-wD8>

We also publish a lot of meaningful shorts on Instagram. You will not see any cat videos there. Our Instagram page is at: <https://www.instagram.com/seraphimholland/> (@seraphimholland)

Please ask us to put you on our parish email list and the Inquirer's list. All you need to do is send your name and email address to seraphim@orthodox.net

Everyone should be subscribed to Father David Straut's mailing list. If you are not receiving the latest services in their entirety, write to him today at this address:

FrDavidStraut@protonmail.com, with the following request: "Please add me to the vigil service's mailing list. Father Seraphim, your number one fan, says hi!" Father David will send you a request, and when you reply to it in the affirmative you will be on his mailing list.

You can also try sending an email with 'Subscribe' in the Subject Line to: VigilServiceTexts+subscribe@groups.io

If you read (and understand) the full text of the services he sends you, you will eventually learn almost everything there is to know about our theology and our practice, and what's more, our "mind", that is, how we look at things, how we approach the world, and the things that are important to us. If you gain knowledge of those services from actually worshiping in them, and a prayer rule and learn about fasting and other ascetical practices, you will be as the Scripture says "not far from the kingdom of God."

I have written another important introductory letter. It has a lot of different things from this letter and repeats some things, but important things need to be repeated. You can access it here: <https://www.orthodox.net/posts/things-all-catechumens-and-inquirers-must-know>

Conclusion

We are always happy to speak with you about your questions and comments, whether about the services you attend or about anything else. God bless you.

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This document:

<https://www.orthodox.net/posts/a-guide-for-inquirers-into-the-orthodox-church>

<http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/guide-for-inquirers-into-the-orthodox-church.pdf>